had lunch with the staff of Daewoo, says Wagh. The employees became votaries of the group and were even emotional about being a part of the Tata family, recalls Kant.

Financially, however, the acquisition looked highly priced. But Ratan saw it differently. He gave Kant the comfort to proceed with the acquisition, telling him: 'How much you pay for it will depend on how desirable the company is for you.' Kant opines that Ratan has the 'ability to think far and take a call and not be stuck with just numbers. He would look at the totality. He has the broad vision, long-term thinking that other people tend to miss out on.'

Daewoo was a great acquisition; it was a 'fantastic pilot' for the Jaguar Land Rover acquisition, which was to come later, as it made the Tata Motors' management comprehend the importance of the 'softer issues' while making acquisitions. It also became a 'beach head' for such ventures and gave them the experience to run a foreign company and helped in the forging of a successful 'World Truck' programme.

The acquisition provided the company 'access to the Korean market' as well as a 'launching pad for possible entry into other markets in the region' especially China. It also gave the group a 10–15 per cent share of the Middle East market. After the acquisition, Ratan said: 'This is indeed a major step for Tata Motors and a milestone for the group in its quest for globalization.' 'He had looked at Tata Motors twenty to thirty years ahead. His emphasis was on new geographies and new technologies,' says Dube. The Daewoo acquisition proved to be a 'big thing' and it helped bring 'back technology to Jamshedpur', says Dhawan.

Simultaneously, the company continued its second leg of the restructuring strategy by consolidating its position in the Indian market, launching new products which included the Indigo Marina, the Tata Novus and a new version of the Indica. Tata Motors also launched a refurbished version of the Tata Sumo, its multiutility vehicle. In 2004, the company, along with Tata Africa, unveiled a range of pick-ups, passenger cars, buses, trucks and utility vehicles for the South African market.

If 2003 saw TELCO recording its highest turnover until then, the following year was spectacular. The top line of the company grew by 43 per cent to Rs 15,552 crore and the bottom line by 170 per cent to Rs 810 crore. Calling it a 'historic year for Tata Motors', Ratan stated that the company had 'posted its highest-ever turnover, profits and vehicle sales volumes'. In